THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

PART VII

Tabreez, February 6, 1846

I don't know whether I mentioned in my last that we were expecting the cholera here. Last year it has been committing dreadful ravages in Afghanistan and in the autumn had come as far as Meshed and Nishahpoor on the way to Tehran. But, thank God, the last news we had of it was that it had turned off to the north among the Turcomanns of the great Khorasan (or Khiva as it is sometimes called) desert. And even had it come to Tehran I see no reason why it should come here, because it might have turned off either north or south from that place or continued its direction from west to east. My friends the Greeks are terribly frightened or rather were. One day I happened to mention that there was a report that the pestilence had arrived at Resht. There were five or six of them in the room and it would have amused you to have seen their blanc faces. It was a false report, but I believe if this disease was to come as near as Tehran not one could be found to remain in the town.

Talking of cholera have you read "the wandering Jew" by Eugene Sue, I have just finished it (the translation in the "Family Herald")[97] and think it a most clever novel, if you have not read it, it will please you much as its aim is to better the condition of the working classes, and unmask the villainy of the Jesuits. It appeared in Nos in this paper from July '44 to October '45. I have seen something of the intrigues of the Lazarist monks in Persia, and these gentry consider themselves as successors to the Jesuits in this country. They have been twice ordered to quit the country with ignominy and disgrace but still hold on altho now their power is much diminished. They formerly had establishments at Ispahan, Ouroumia and here, now they have only a small establishment in the district of Salmas, to the N: W: of this on the frontier. I have had to fight against their plots to injure my friends the American missionaries.[98] And what at first sight seems most strange is that the agent of France, at this court, liberal, revolutionary France, the France of July 1830, supports these black coated gentry with all his power. I believe the reason of this may be that as the French have no interest in these countries and consequently no pretence for placing agents or consuls, and not liking from their vanity, to have nothing to do with the politics of these

[97] A London weekly periodical. The New York Public Library has most of the numbers from 1844–1891 (* DE).

[98] Perkins, op. cit., *passim,* has precisely the same complaints against the Jesuits.

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